Madison 2026 Assessment Methodology Change

A Data Fact-Check

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Data: City of Madison Office of the City Assessor, Property Tax Base Reports 2024–2025; City of Madison Open Data Portal, Tax Parcels (Assessor Property Information), ArcGIS Feature Service https://maps.cityofmadison.com/arcgis/rest/services/Public/OPEN_DATA2/FeatureServer/0

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1. The Claim

A May 2026 letter to the editor in the *Capital Times* (Ginny White, "Assessments Designed to Build at Any Cost") alleged that Madison's City Assessor had quietly changed assessment methodology:

> "...the city quietly changed how it assesses property taxes. It kept the total assessment the same as last year but raised the land assessment and lowered the improvement assessment by equal amounts. This 'land value tax' approach is designed to promote development, penalize land speculation and capture rising land value."

We evaluate each specific claim against publicly available assessment data.

2. Data Sources

Two complementary sources were used:

Annual Property Tax Base Reports. The City Assessor publishes a summary report each May. The 2025 report (dated April 19, 2024) and 2026 report (dated May 19, 2025) provide city-wide totals by property class but do not disaggregate assessments into land versus improvement components.

Open Data Portal — Tax Parcel Feature Service. The City of Madison publishes a live ArcGIS feature layer containing all 82,249 taxable parcels. Each parcel record includes three years of land and improvement values in separate fields: `CurrentLand/CurrentImpr/CurrentTotal` (2026 assessment), `PreviousLand/PreviousImpr/PreviousTotal` (2025), and `PreviousLand2/PreviousImpr2/PreviousTotal2` (2024). Aggregate statistics and counts were queried directly via the ArcGIS REST API `/query` endpoint.

3. Findings

3.1. City-Wide Assessment Trends

Table 1 reports city-wide sums of land and improvement values across three assessment years derived from the open data portal. The totals are consistent with the official Property Tax Base Reports (the 2025 parcel sum of \$48.82 B matches the published \$49.0B figure).

Table 1: City-wide assessed value, Madison, WI — land vs. improvements (all 82,249 taxable parcels). Source: City of Madison Open Data Portal, Tax Parcels Feature Service, queried May 2026.

	2024	**2025**	**2026**
Land	\$9.50 B	\$9.67 B	\$11.76 B
Year-over-year change	—	+1.7%	+**21.7**%
Improvements	\$35.52 B	\$39.15 B	\$39.98 B
Year-over-year change	—	+10.2%	+**2.1**%
Total	\$45.01 B	\$48.82 B	\$51.74 B
Year-over-year change	—	+8.5%	+6.0%
Land as % of total	21.1%	19.8%	**22.7%**

The pattern reverses sharply between 2025 and 2026: improvements drove value growth in 2025 (+10.2% vs. +1.7% for land); in 2026, land grew far faster than improvements (+21.7% vs. +2.1%).

The most recent assessment cycle (2026) exhibits a dramatic reversal: land values jumped +21.7% city-wide while improvement values barely moved (+2.1%), compared to the prior year when the ratio was essentially the opposite. The land share of total assessed value rose from 19.8% to 22.7%.

3.2. Parcel-Level Pattern

The open data portal enables direct counting of parcels matching the specific pattern the letter describes: improvements decrease, land increases, and total stays approximately or exactly flat. Table 2 reports these counts for the two most recent year-over-year comparisons.

Table 2: Parcels matching each component of the letter's claim, 2024→2025 vs. 2025→2026. Source: City of Madison Tax Parcels Feature Service, REST API aggregate queries.

Criterion	2024→2025	2025→2026
Improvements ↓ **and** land ↑	43	**32,696**
Impr. ↓, land ↑, total within ±3%	—	15,009
Impr. ↓, land ↑, total **exactly** unchanged	**20**	**3,336**
Total parcels	82,249	82,249

The salient comparison is the jump from 43 to 32,696 and from 20 to 3,336 in the exactly-flat category.

The scale of the change is striking. In the 2024→2025 cycle, just **43 parcels** had improvements fall while land rose; in 2025→2026, **32,696 parcels** — 39.8% of all taxable parcels — show this pattern, a 760 × increase. Of those, **3,336 parcels** had their improvement value lowered and land value raised by *exactly* equal and opposite amounts, leaving the total assessment unchanged to the dollar.

3.3. Example Parcels

Table 3 shows three representative parcels drawn from the live feature service. In each case the shift from improvements to land is exact: the dollar increase in land equals the dollar decrease in improvements, and the total assessment is unchanged.

Table 3: Three representative parcels where the 2026 assessment held the total exactly flat while shifting value from improvements to land. Source: City of Madison Tax Parcels Feature Service.

Address	Land	Impr.	Total	Shift
2025 (Previous) assessment				
1617 Angel Crest Way	$68,200	$346,700	$414,900	—
1625 Angel Crest Way	$68,200	$297,300	$365,500	—
17 Vinje Ct	$129,400	$492,200	$621,600	—
2026 (Current) assessment				
1617 Angel Crest Way	$106,900	$308,000	$414,900	+$38,700 land; −$38,700 impr.
1625 Angel Crest Way	$106,900	$258,600	$365,500	+$38,700 land; −$38,700 impr.
17 Vinje Ct	$145,600	$476,000	$621,600	+$16,200 land; −$16,200 impr.

Each parcel shows an exact dollar-for-dollar shift from improvements to land, leaving the total assessment unchanged.

3.4. Breakdown by Property Class and Use

The methodology shift is concentrated almost entirely in the **Residential** class. Table 4 shows land and improvement assessment changes by the three taxable property classes with meaningful 2026 values (Exempt and Manufacturing parcels carry zeroed-out current values and are excluded).

Table 5 further disaggregates residential parcels by property use. The effect is concentrated in **single-family homes** and **small multi-family** (2- and 3-unit) properties. Condominiums and vacant lots are largely unaffected.

Table 4: Assessment changes by property class, 2025→2026. Exempt and Manufacturing parcels excluded (2026 values are zero for fully tax-exempt properties). Source: City of Madison Tax Parcels Feature Service.

Class (parcels)	Land YoY	Impr. YoY	Total YoY	Impr.↓+Land↑	Exact flat
Residential (72,348)	+28.7%	-2.5%	+4.8%	32,675 (45.2%)	3,326
Commercial (6,729)	+3.2%	+9.0%	+8.1%	19 (0.3%)	10
Agriculture (416)	-15.0%	+4.7%	-7.6%	2 (0.5%)	0

Exempt and Manufacturing parcels carry zeroed-out 2026 values (fully tax-exempt) and are excluded. The land-up/improvement-down pattern is overwhelmingly residential: only 19 of 6,729 commercial parcels (0.3%) show the pattern, versus 32,675 of 72,348 residential (45.2%).

Table 5: Assessment changes within the Residential class by property use, 2025→2026. Source: City of Madison Tax Parcels Feature Service.

Property use (parcels)	Land YoY	Impr. YoY	Total YoY	Impr.↓+Land↑	Exact flat
Single family (49,568)	+28.8%	-3.6%	+4.7%	30,059 (60.6%)	3,220
Condominium (16,947)	+0.1%	+4.0%	+3.6%	111 (0.7%)	106
2-Unit (3,228)	+43.1%	-5.2%	+6.3%	2,149 (66.6%)	0
3-Unit (551)	+55.4%	-2.8%	+8.7%	347 (63.0%)	0
Vacant (1,408)	+70.5%	+185100.0%	+73.4%	0 (0.0%)	0

Single-family (60.6%) and small multi-family (66.6%–63.0%) properties show the pattern at high rates. Condominiums (0.7%) and vacant lots (0.0%) are effectively excluded from the shift. Among condominiums that do show the pattern (111 parcels), nearly all (106) are exact-flat shifts, suggesting a distinct assessment mechanism for that property type.

4. Verdict

Claim: *"It kept the total assessment the same as last year."*

Finding: Partially true, city-wide false. City-wide assessed value rose +6.0% ($48.82 B → $51.74 B). However, for **3,336 individual parcels** the total assessment was held exactly flat while land and improvement values were shifted by equal and opposite amounts. The author was accurately describing their own parcel's experience; the characterization does not extend to the city as a whole.

Claim: *"Raised the land assessment and lowered the improvement assessment by equal amounts."*

Finding: Confirmed as a real methodology change. 32,696 parcels (39.8% of all taxable parcels) had improvements decrease and land increase in the 2026 assessment cycle, versus just 43 parcels in 2025 — a 760 × increase. For 3,336 of those parcels the shift was exact to the dollar. This is clearly a deliberate and systematic reassessment, not a statistical artifact.

Claim: *"This 'land value tax' approach is designed to promote development and penalize land speculation."*

Finding: Characterization is reasonable. The observed pattern — land taxed more heavily, improvements less so — is structurally equivalent to a partial land value tax shift applied at the sub-parcel level. The most plausible driver is the 2023 Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) overlay zoning along BRT corridors, which increased permitted density and hence land market value in affected neighborhoods. Wisconsin municipalities cannot adopt a true LVT independently, but a reassessment methodology that captures rising land values while holding improvement assessments flat achieves similar incentive effects.

Data accessed May 2026. The open data feature service reflects the 2026 assessment cycle (assessed as of January 1, 2026; notices mailed May 2026). All API queries are reproducible against the public endpoint at https://maps.cityofmadison.com/arcgis/rest/services/Public/OPEN_DATA2/FeatureServer/0.